

Figure 1: In a smartphone, 'off' does not mean really 'off'

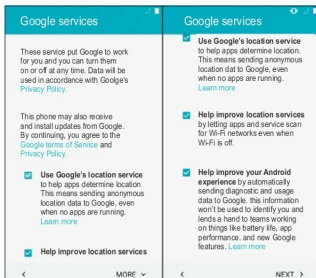


Figure 2: To enable data collection, Google apps have almost complete control on your device

Photos app, which lets Google Settings upload your photos even after the app is uninstalled. You do not need the Gmail app to get email. Use Gmail's Web interface to enable POP or IMAP access in the settings. Then, configure Gmail POP/IMAP access in the stock email app and use it to send/receive email. Other providers such as Microsoft (Outlook) and Yahoo also provide free POP/IMAP access.

In the February 2016 edition of *OSFY*, Magimai Prakash has provided an introduction to F-Droid. This app is a good alternative to Google Play. F-Droid provides downloads of FOSS apps. It has plenty of apps for every purpose.

App stores from Amazon, Yandex and Opera are alternatives to Google Play. Unfortunately, the Amazon store app is even more resource-heavy than Google Play. These store apps have their own data collection methods. The only



Figure 3: Stop and disable unwanted apps



Figure 4: The F-Droid app is a FOSS alternative to Google Play

minor difference is that their pipes are not connected to Google data centres.

Side-load apps

You will have to enable the *Unknown sources* option in the settings for side-loading apps. Whenever I have to configure a new device, I install all the apps (mostly games) that I need from Google Play before disabling it and all its associated apps. I then use Total Commander (a file manager app) to copy APK installer files of the apps to an SD card backup store.

If ever I need to install those apps again, I can get them from the backup.

There are many sites that provide free downloads of APK files. Installing apps from these sources is fraught with danger. *AndroidPolice.com* maintains a site at www.apkmirror.com where the latest APK builds are uploaded for testing. XDA Forums is a site famous for its Android developer community. Many APK files that are not available on app stores can be downloaded from here. Always read the reviews before installing any APK.

Racoon is a Google Play desktop client. It is a Java software that you can run on Linux, Windows or Mac computers. It does not break Google's ToC. You have to log in to a valid Google account to download the APK files, which can then be manually installed on your phone. There is no need to have Google Play on the device.

In my opinion, F-Droid is the best alternative to all the rest.